

Family and Society in Islam

Thursday, November 20, 2025

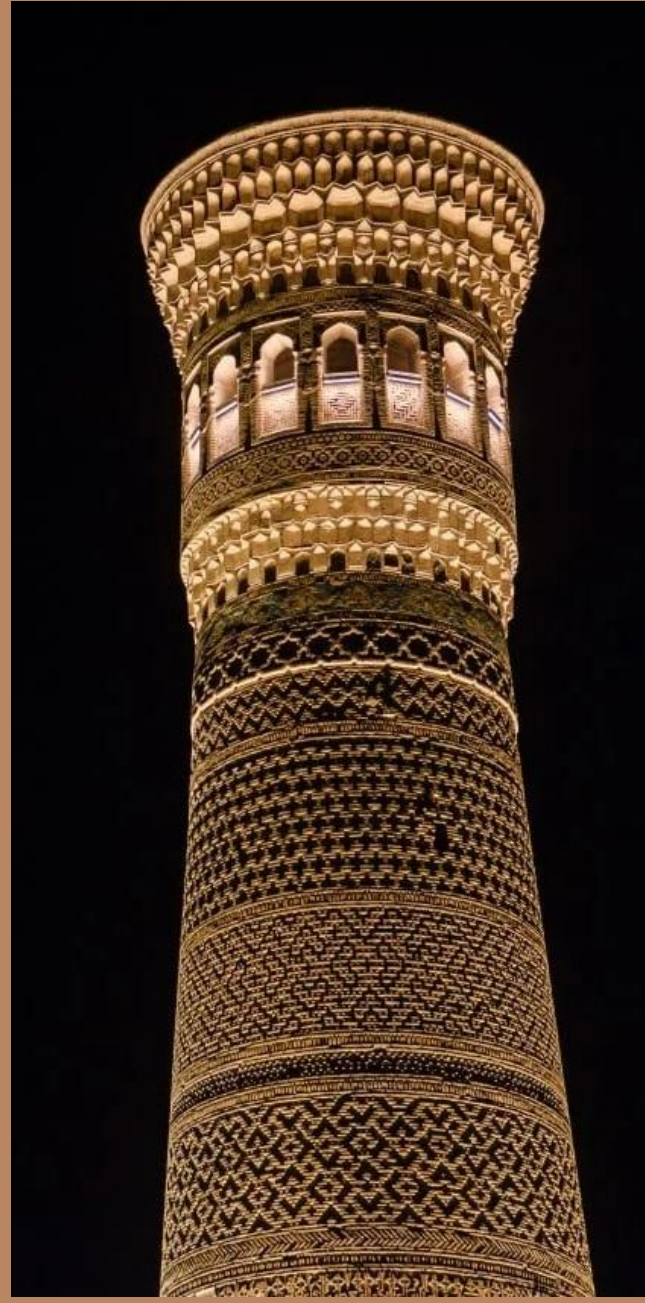
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بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم

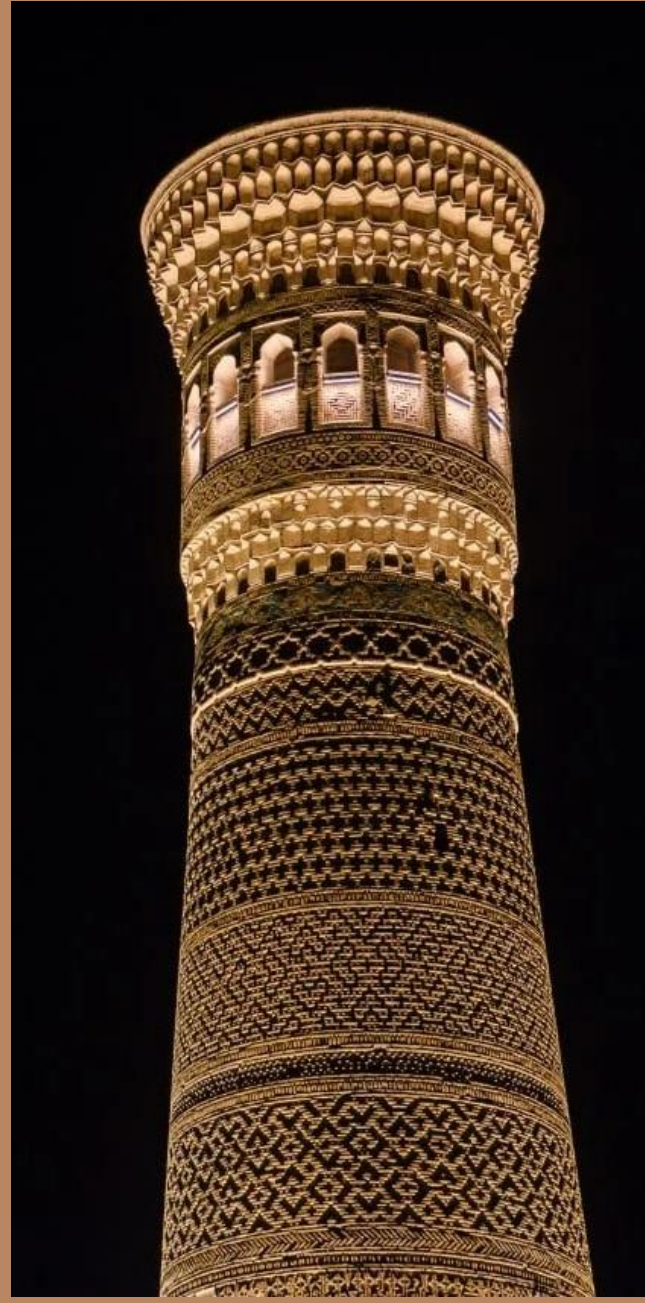
Sila Rahim

- As a terminology, it is defined by Imam Nawawi as: Sila Rahim means to do good to the relatives according to the circumstances of both the one maintaining the ties and the one receiving them. Sometimes this is done through financial support, sometimes through provifing helpful service, sometimes through visits, greetings, and other means.
- Ibn Manzur clarified the relationship between the linguistic and terminological meanings, saying: It is a metaphor for showing kindness to relatives by blood and marriage, being compassionate towards them, being gentle with them, and attending to their needs, even if they are distant or have wronged you. Cutting kinship ties is the opposite of all this.



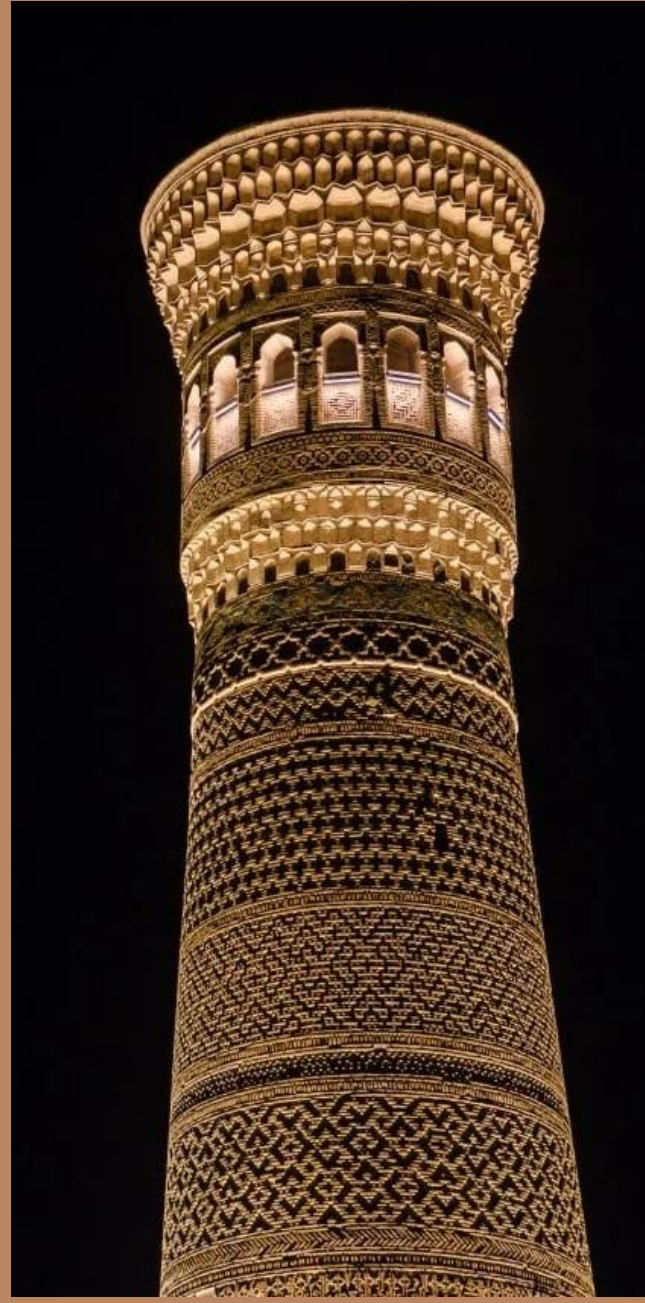
Sila Rahim

- Qadi Iyad said: There is no disagreement that maintaining kinship ties is obligatory in general, and severing them is a major sin, and the Sunnah testify to this. However, maintaining these ties has degrees, some higher than others. The lowest degree is refraining from severing ties through speech, even if only through greetings. This varies according to ability and need; some aspects are obligatory, and others are recommended. If someone maintains some of the ties but not their full extent, they are not considered to have severed them. Similarly, if someone falls short of what they are capable of and what is appropriate, they are not considered to have maintained them.



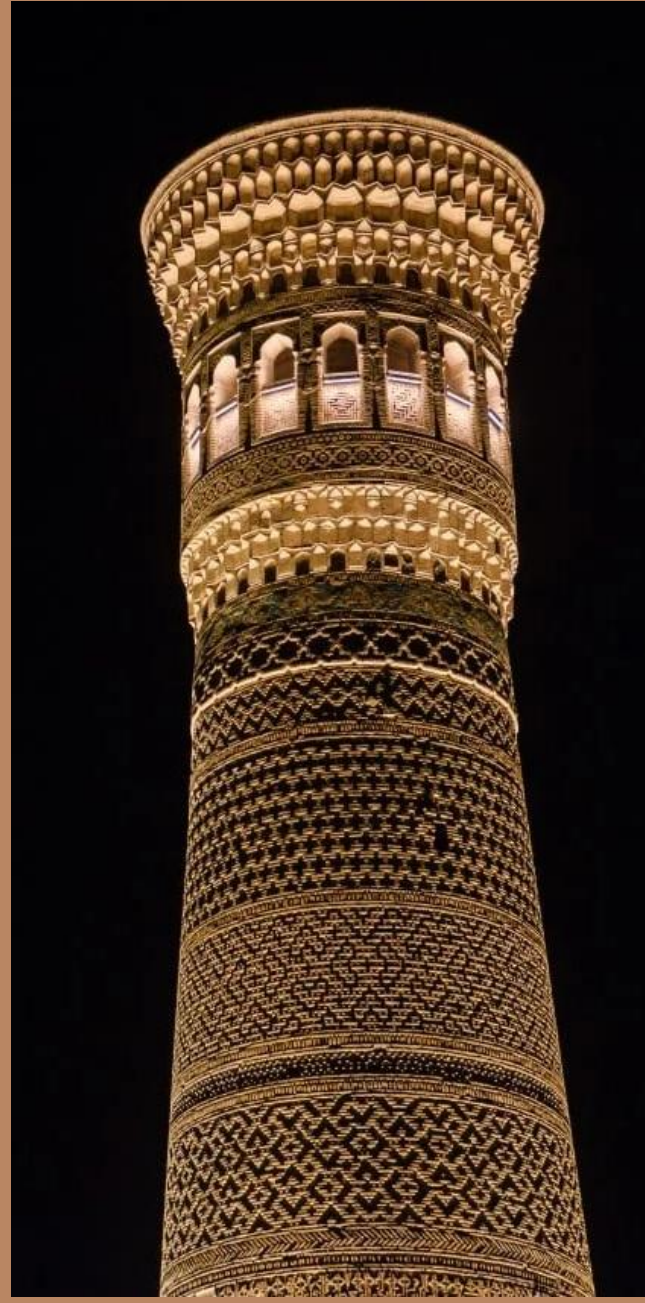
Sila Rahim How to Practice

- Abu al-Barakat Badr al-Din Muhammad al-Ghazzi said: Good companionship and fellowship with family and children is achieved through gentleness, generosity, providing to fulfil their needs, teaching them good manners and the Sunnah, and guiding them towards obedience, as Allah Almighty says: “O you who have believed, protect yourselves and your families from a Fire whose fuel is people and stones.”



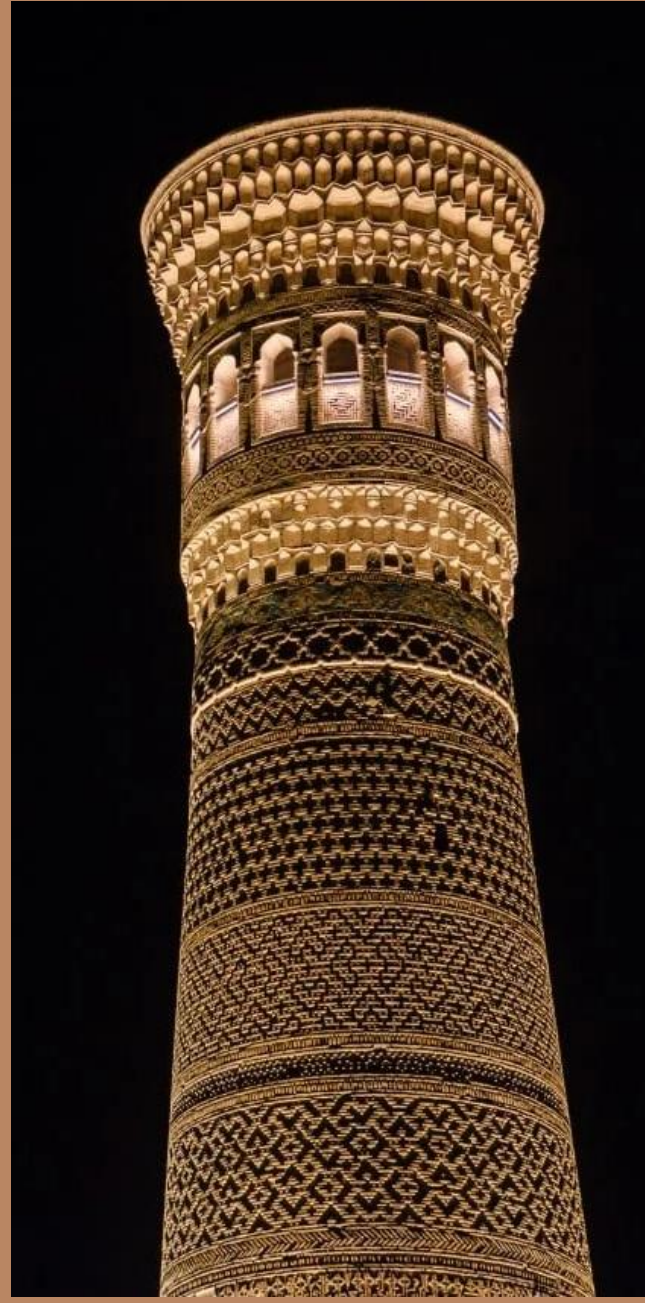
Ayaat

And when We made a covenant with the children of Israel: You shall not worhip any but Allah and (you shall do) good to (your) parents, and to the near of kin and to the orphans and the needy, and you shall speak to men good words and keep up prayer and pay Zakat. Then you turned back except a few of you and (now too) you turn aside. (Al-Quran)



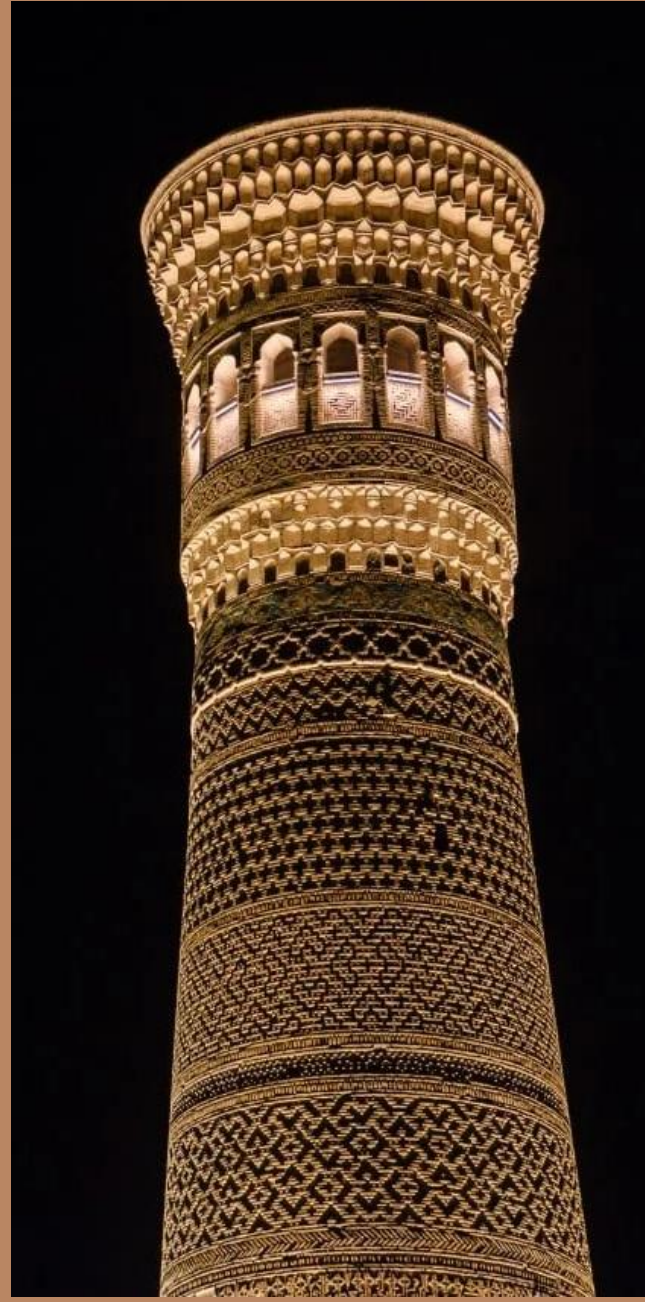
Ayaat

It is not righteousness that you turn your faces towards the East and the West, but righteousness is this that one should believe in Allah and the last day and the angels and the Book and the prophets, and give away wealth out of love for Him to the near of kin and the orphans and the needy and the wayfarer and the beggars and for (the emancipation of) the captives, and keep up prayer and pay the poor-rate; and the performers of their promise when they make a promise, and the patient in distress and affliction and in time of conflicts--these are they who are true (to themselves) and these are they who guard (against evil). (Al-Quran)



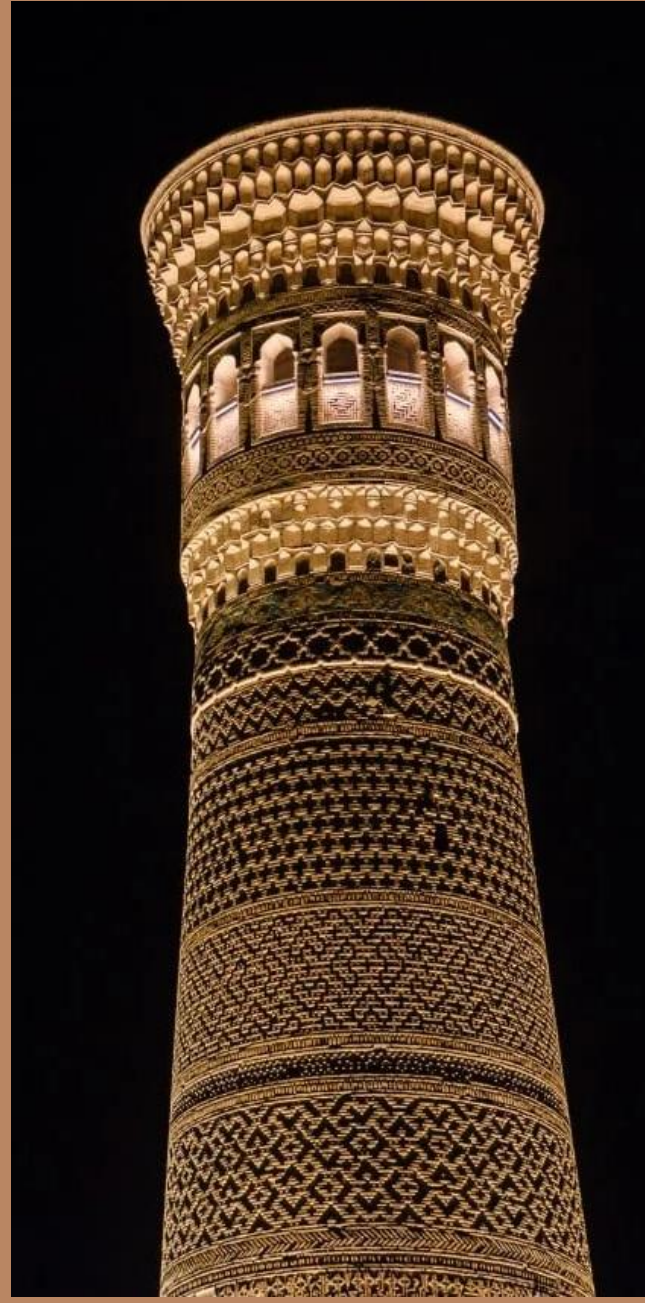
Ayaat

Indeed, Allah orders justice and good conduct and giving to relatives and forbids lewdness and abomination and wickedness. He admonishes you that perhaps you will be reminded.



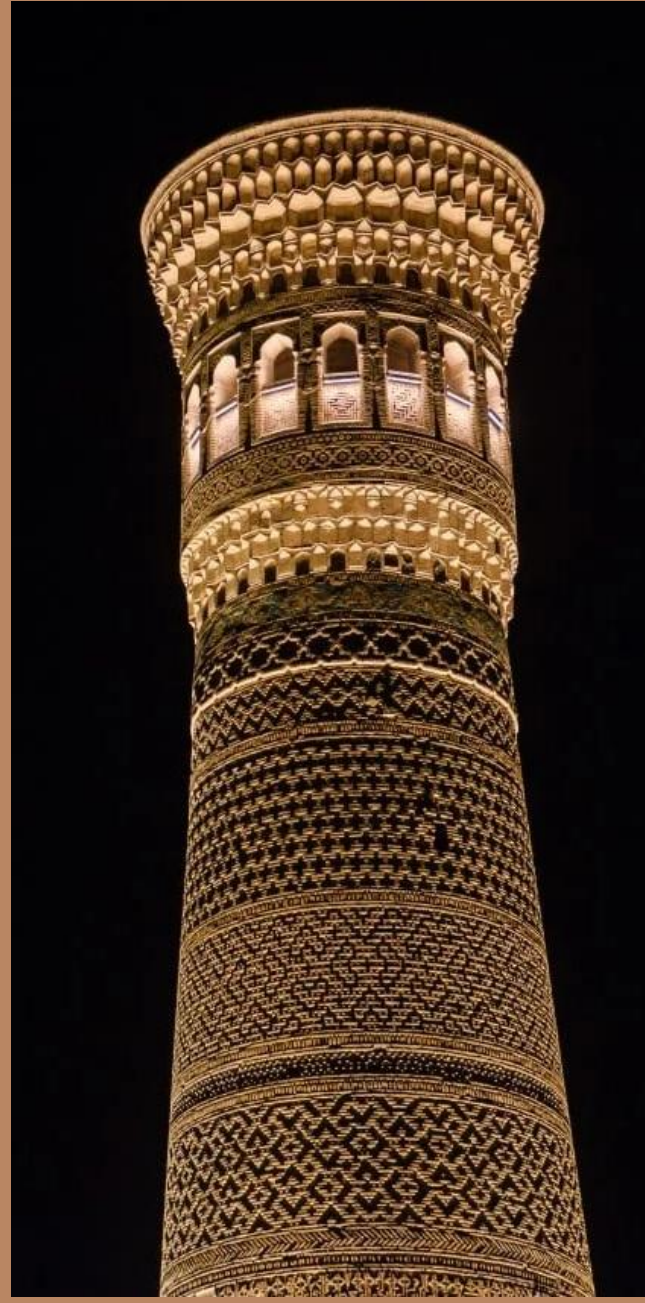
Ayaat

Worship Allah and join none with Him (in worship); and do good to parents, kinsfolk, orphans, Al-Masakin (the poor), the neighbour who is near of kin, the neighbour who is a stranger, the companion by your side, the wayfarer (you meet), and those (slaves) whom your right hands possess. Verily, Allah does not like such as are proud and boastful. (Al-Quran)



1. Situations where “doing good” to kin is overruled

You will not find a people who believe in Allah and the Last Day having affection for those who oppose Allah and His Messenger, even if they were their fathers or their sons or their brothers or their kindred. As for such, He hath written faith upon their hearts and hath strengthened them with a Spirit from Him, and He will bring them into Gardens underneath which rivers flow, wherein they will abide. Allah is well pleased with them, and they are well pleased with Him. They are Allah's party. (Al-Quran)



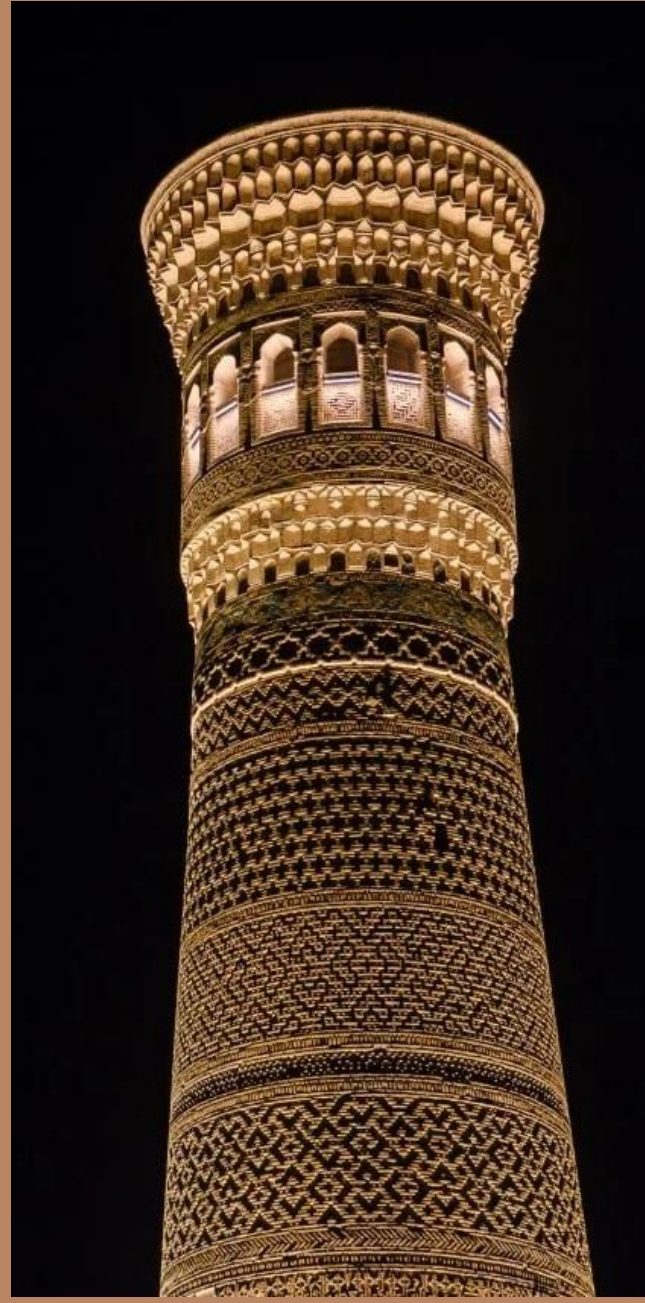
1. Situations where “doing good” to kin is overruled

O ye who believe! Choose not your fathers nor your brethren for friends if they take pleasure in disbelief rather than faith. Whoso of you taketh them for friends, such are wrong-doers. Say: If your fathers, and your sons, and your brethren, and your wives, and your tribe, and the wealth ye have acquired, and merchandise for which ye fear that there will no sale, and dwellings ye desire are dearer to you than Allah and His messenger and striving in His way: then wait till Allah bringeth His command to pass. Allah guideth not wrongdoing folk.



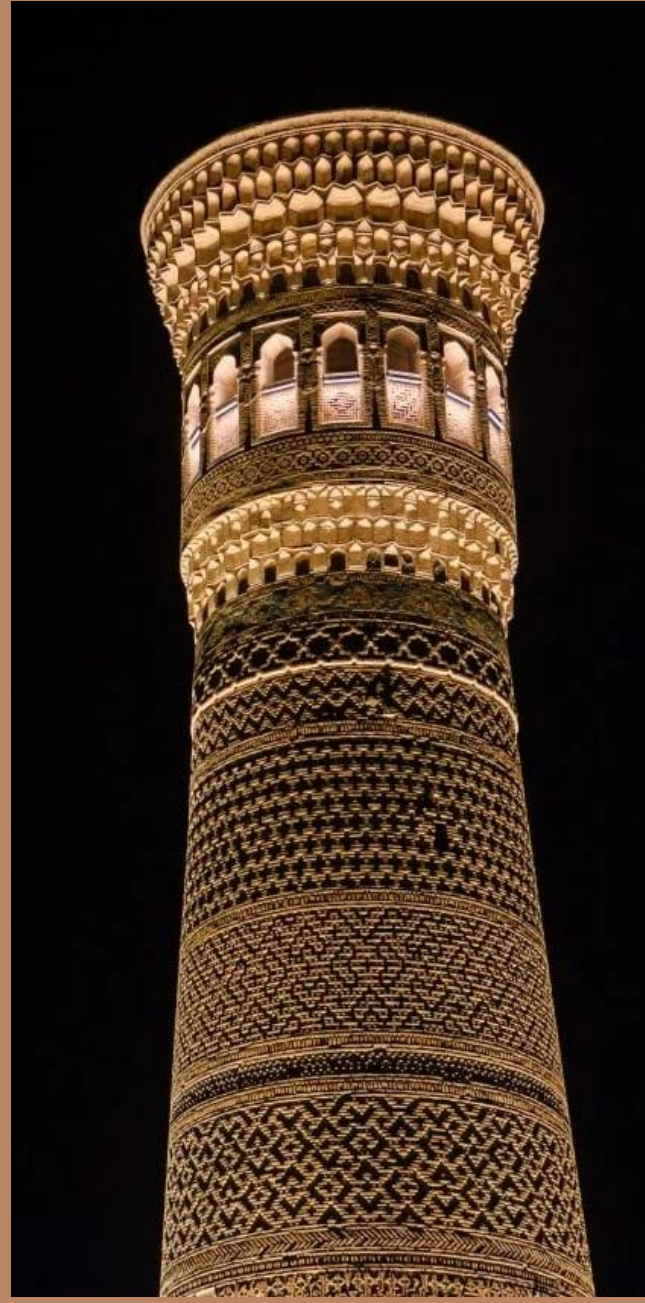
2. Situations where “doing good” to kin is overruled

And when it is said unto them: Follow that which Allah hath revealed, they say: We follow that wherein we found our fathers. What! Even though their fathers were wholly unintelligent and had no guidance?



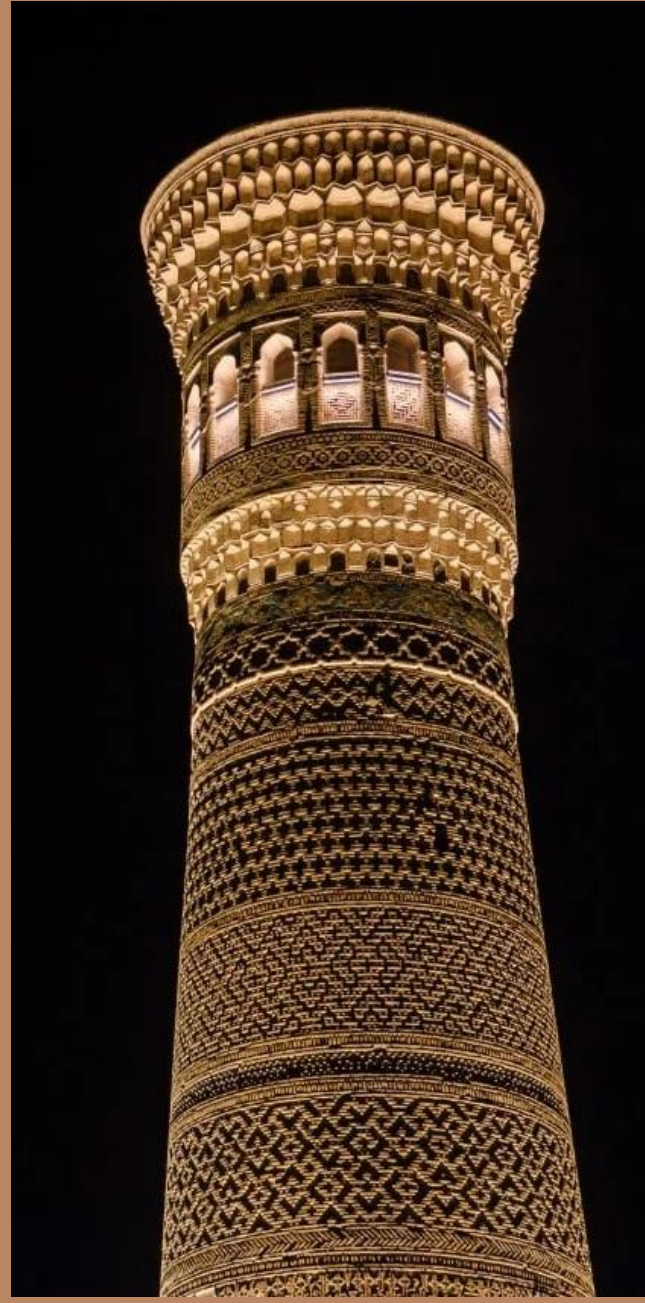
3. Situations where “doing good” to kin is overruled

If you are in doubt (about their truthfulness), let them both swear by Allah (saying): “We wish not for any worldly gain in this, even though he (the beneficiary) be our near relative. We shall not hide Testimony of Allah, for then indeed we should be of the sinful.” (Al-Quran)



3. Situations where “doing good” to kin is overruled

- It was narrated from Anas bin Malik, that the Prophet (s.a.w) said: “Help your brother whether he is an oppressor or oppressed.” It was said: “O Messenger of Allah! I help him when he is oppressed. But how can I help him when he oppresses?” He said: “Prevent him from oppression, that is your help for him.” (Al-Hadith)



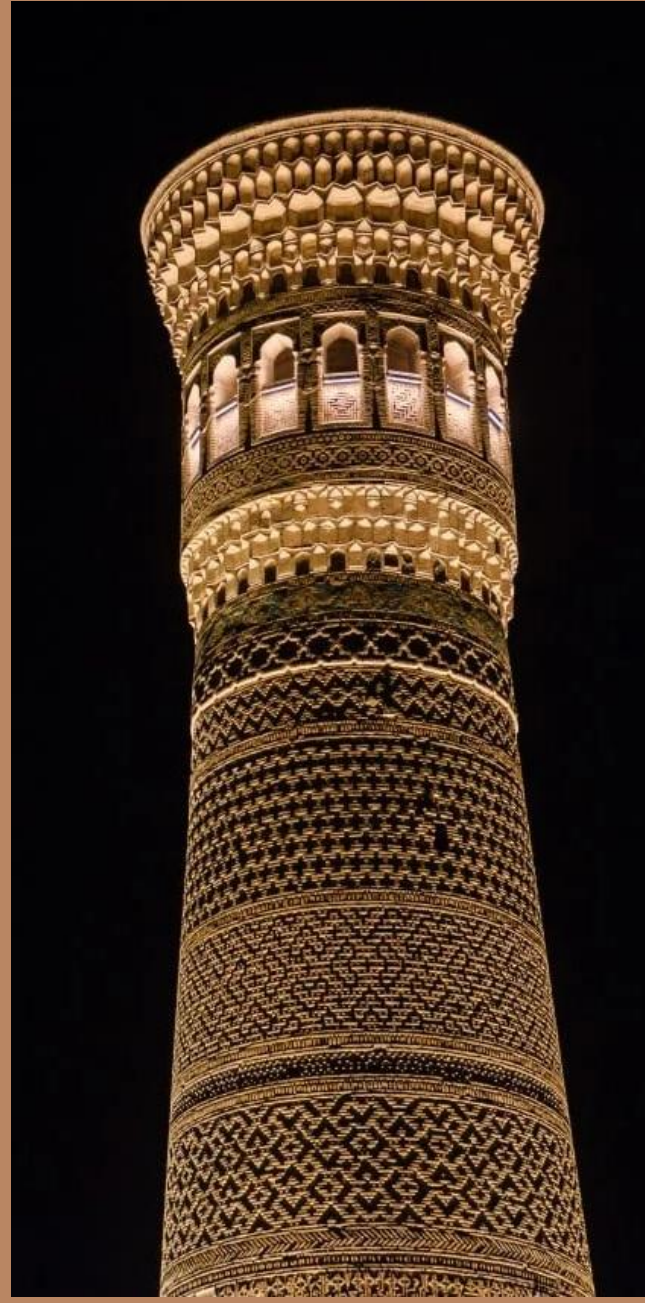
Best Good to the Kinship

And make mention in the Scripture of Ishmael. Lo! he was a keeper of his promise, and he was a messenger (of Allah), a prophet. And he used to command his family to offer Salat and give Zakat, and his Lord was pleased with him. (Al-Quran)



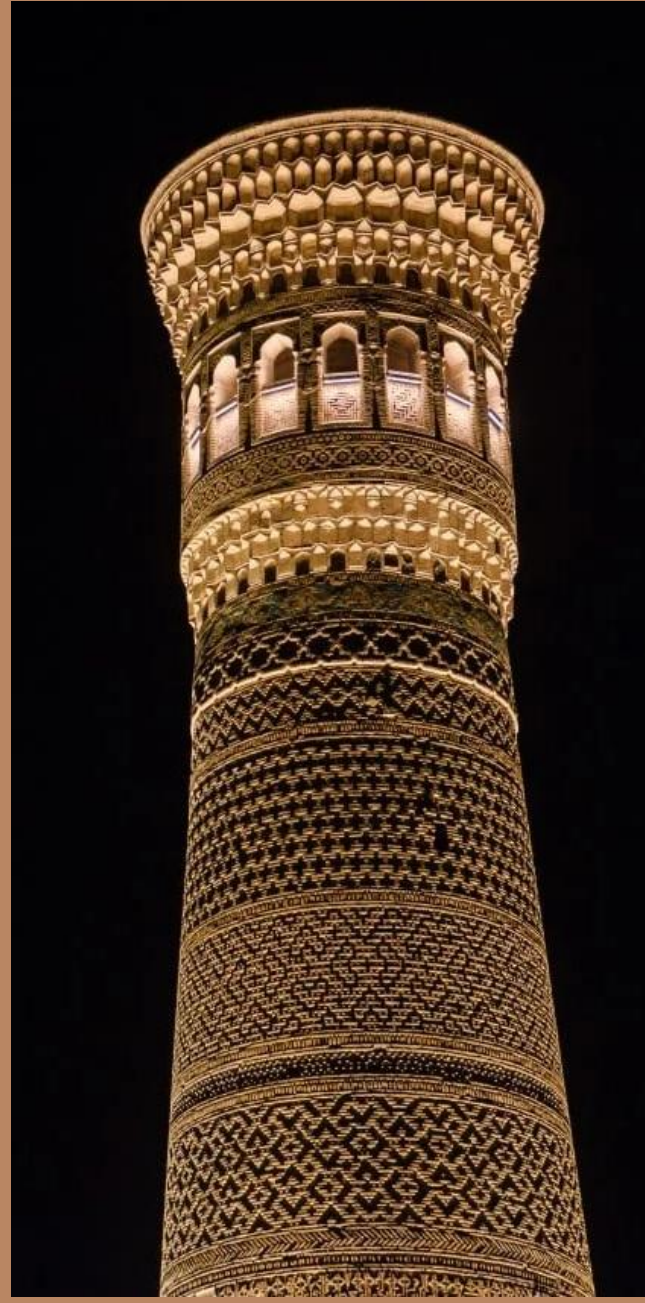
Families on the Day of Judgement

But when there comes the Deafening Blast. On the Day a man will flee from his brother. And from his mother and his father. And from his wife and his children. Everyman that Day will have enough to make him careless of others.



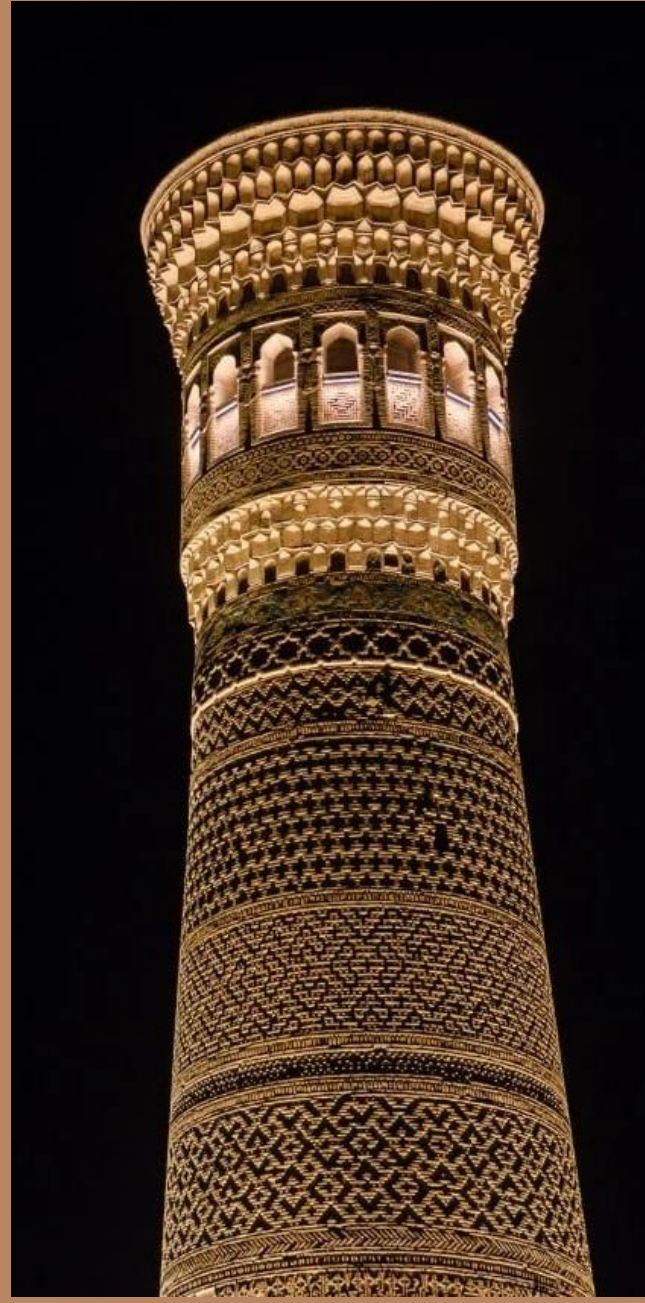
Families on the Day of Judgement

And no friend will ask a friend (about his condition), They will be shown each other. The criminal will wish that he could be ransomed from the punishment of that Day by his children. And his wife and his brother. And the nearest of his kinsfolk who gave him shelter. And whoever is on earth entirely [so] then it could save him. No! Indeed, it is the Flame [of Hell].



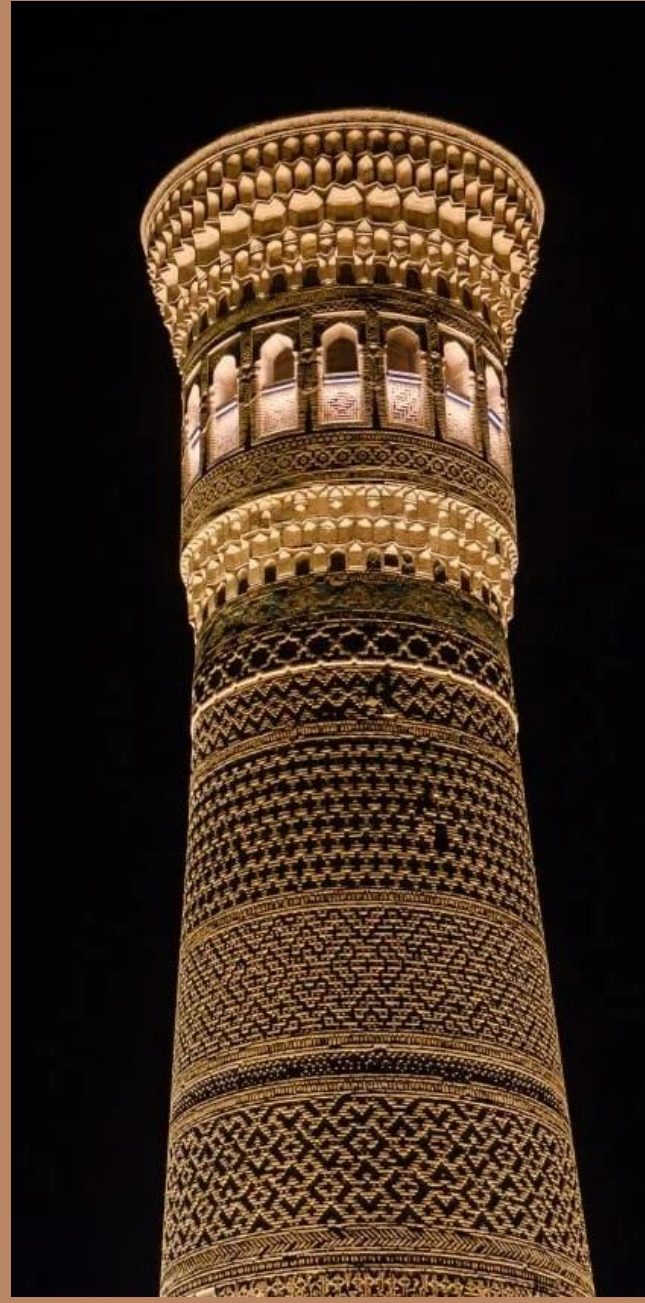
Families on the Day of Judgement

And no bearer of burdens will bear the burden of another. And if a heavily laden soul calls [another] to [carry some of] its load, nothing of it will be carried, even if he should be a close relative. (Al-Quran)



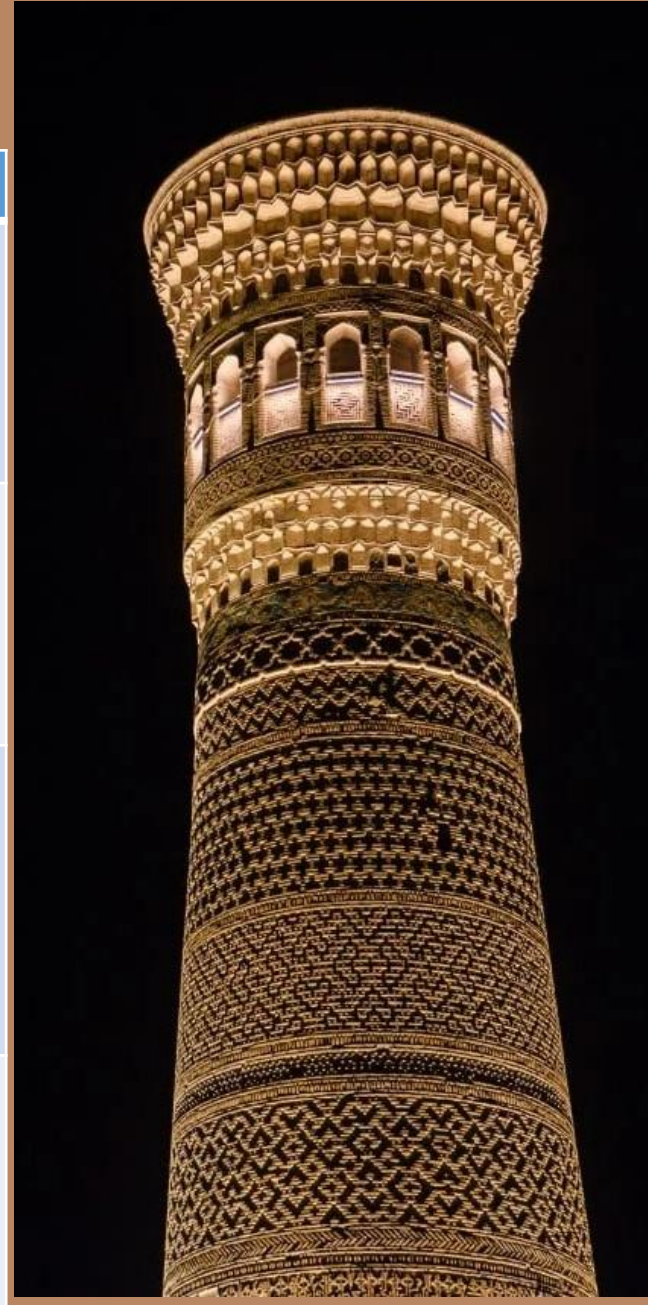
Major Issues Within Extended Family Networks in Pakistan

1. Inheritance and Property Disputes: Division of family land, assets, or ancestral property. Siblings or cousins, leading to prolonged legal battles and familial rifts.
2. Interference in Marital and Reproductive Decisions: Exert influence on marriage alliances, dowry expectations, and family making decisions, resulting in tensions between nuclear and extended family members.
3. Tribal or Revenge-Based Feuds: Long-standing enmities rooted in honor, land, or past grievances can escalate into violence across extended families and perpetuating cycles of retaliation across generations.
4. Generational and Privacy Conflicts: The shift toward nuclear family units amid urbanization creates friction with elders' expectations of deference and involvement, leading to issues of privacy invasion, blurred boundaries, overbearing control, and emotional strain on younger members.
5. In-law and marital tensions (daughter-in-law / mother-in-law conflicts) — Power imbalances inside joint households, unclear roles, and expectations about obedience and household authority produce chronic friction that affects spouses and children.



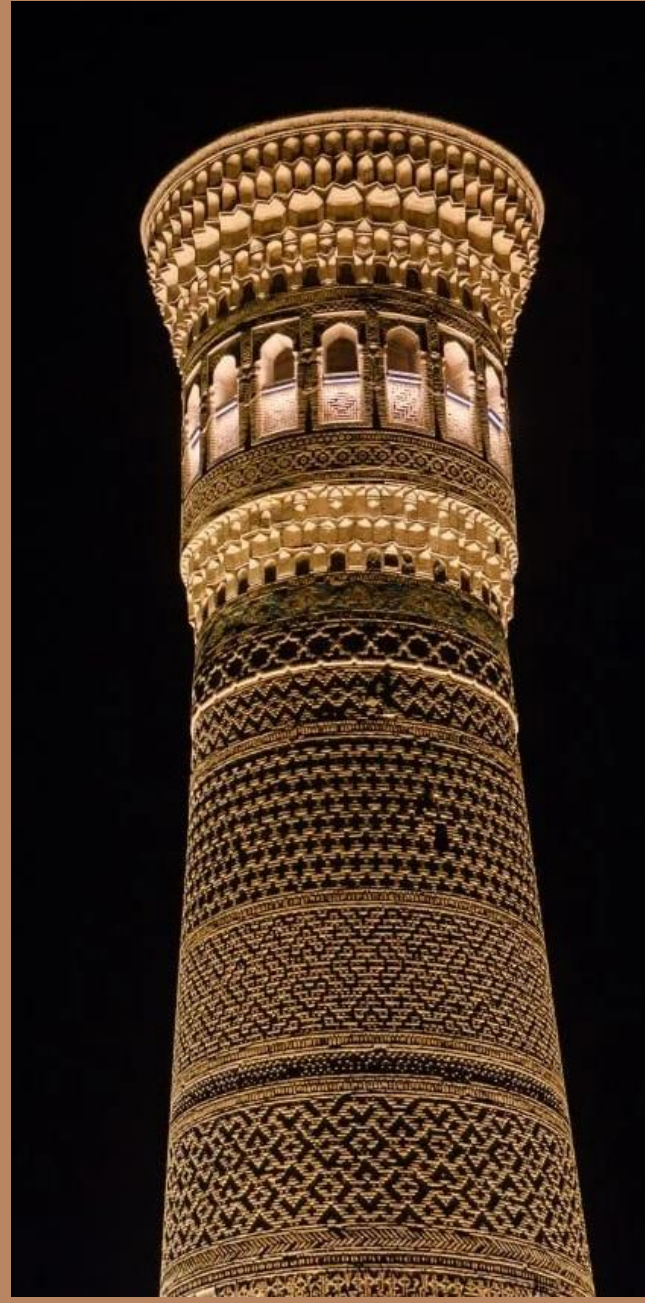
What Usually Happens

Strategy	Description/Example
1. Emotional Blackmail and Guilt-Tripping	A parent uses phrases like, "You will see my coffin before you leave this house" or "You are breaking our family," to prevent an adult child from moving into their own home or making personal decisions. This inflicts severe, long-term guilt and mental health crises on the adult child, often forcing them to stay in an unhealthy or suffocating environment, leading to marital breakdown. **Moving out? That's a direct ticket to ancestral disapproval and emergency room visits !**
2. Public Shaming and Reputation Damage	In a dispute (e.g., over a divorce or property), one family faction publicly shames the other through gossip, spreading false rumors, or involving extended tribal/caste structures (biradari) to pressure them. This severely damages the targeted family's repute, marriage prospects, and mental well-being, often escalating the conflict beyond resolution. **Biradari Broadcast Cystem (BBC) releases the news faster than any media. Who needs social media when you have your Aunty with a cellphone?**
3. Avoidance and Denial (Ignoring the Problem)	To maintain the façade of family unity (izzat), serious issues like domestic violence, emotional abuse, or a child's mental health struggles are completely ignored or denied by the elders. The victim is told to do sabr and adjust for the sake of the family. This leads to the problem worsening, culminating in a violent incident, a secret elopement. The elders deny the reality so hard that the problem simply grows into a monster—a monster that eventually burns down the house, elopes, or forces a dramatic exit. **The family motto: If we don't look at the fire, it cannot burn us!**
4. Exclusion from Inheritance (The Will)	To punish a son who married against the family's wishes or a daughter who demanded her Islamic right to inheritance, the parents retaliate by becoming 'Estate Planning Ninjas,' and unlawfully disinherit them or transfer all property to the "obedient" children through a fraudulent will. This leads to decades-long legal battles, permanent estrangement, and a complete fracture of the entire family unit, sometimes resulting in bloodshed. **Better to marry your cousin for the sake of property!**



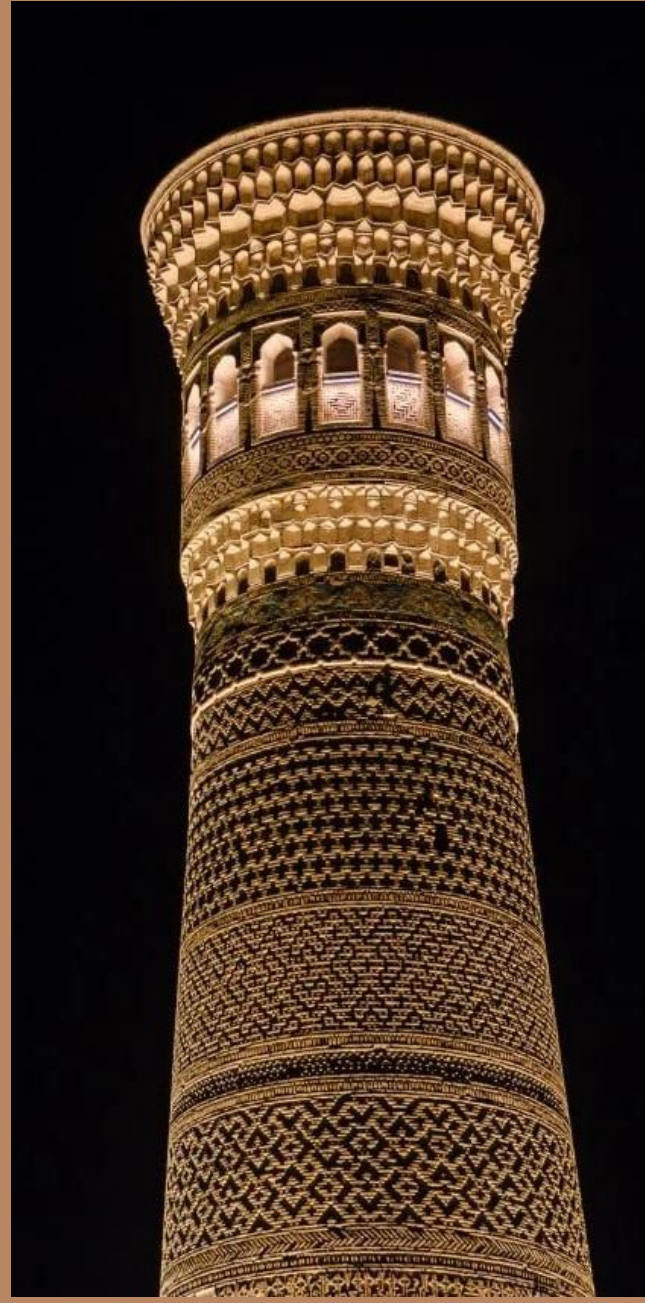
Wise Examples

Strategy	Description/Example
1. Planned Transition to Nuclear Living	A son and his wife mutually decide to move out of the joint house for better professional opportunities and privacy, but they do so after openly discussing a clear plan with the parents (e.g., weekly visits, phone calls, consistent financial support for parents). The parents' initial resistance is managed with empathy and consistent reassurance that the physical distance does not mean emotional abandonment.
2. Establishing Financial Clarity	In a family business, the elder siblings proactively formalize the financial structure. They create a legal partnership deed with clear salaries, profit-sharing percentages, and defined roles. This prevents future disputes by separating family relationships from business obligations, allowing different family branches to manage their personal finances independently without suspicion.
3. Patriarch/Matriarch as a Neutral Mediator	A respected elder (often the mother/father) refuses to "take sides" in a conflict between siblings or between a daughter-in-law and her husband/sister-in-law. They hold private, non-judgmental mediation sessions, using values like sabr (patience) and lihaz/riyayat (accommodation) to encourage dialogue and a fair, practical solution (e.g., giving the couple a separate portion of the house or a fixed schedule for joint chores).
4. Empowering the Daughter-in-Law (DIL)	A mother-in-law (MIL) or father-in-law (FIL) publicly supports their DIL's right to privacy. By vocally defending her autonomy against other relatives' criticism, they demonstrate a commitment to the couple's progress and the DIL's personhood. This act of validation prevents the DIL from feeling isolated and builds a strong foundation of respect and loyalty towards the in-laws.



Examples of Poor Management

1. Peshawar Family Feud Shootout (2025): A dispute over land inheritance in Peshawar's Khatko Pul area escalated into a deadly exchange of fire between two extended family branches, resulting in six deaths, including three women. Despite police intervention, the failure to pursue early mediation prolonged the conflict, rooted in longstanding property grievances.
2. Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Vendetta Ambush (2023): A decades-old family feud in Lakki Marwat district culminated in gunmen ambushing a convoy, killing 11 individuals, including a local politician. The extended clan's refusal to engage jirga (tribal council) reconciliation perpetuated the cycle of retaliation, highlighting the dangers of unresolved historical enmities.
3. Rawalpindi Intra-Family Shooting (2025): In a property-related feud in Rawalpindi, a man shot dead his brother and nephew after accusing them of aiding police in his prior offense. This violent outburst, stemming from unaddressed sibling rivalries within an extended family, left three dead and exemplified how personal betrayals can fracture kin networks irreparably.



Examples of Poor Management

1. Sindh (Karachi, July 2024): A 14-year-old girl named Shahzadi, who had sought judicial protection from an abusive ex-spouse through the Sindh High Court, was fatally attacked by her maternal uncle shortly after receiving the order. The conflict, involving oppressive marital arrangements and familial retaliation, escalated without protective measures from extended relatives, exemplifying systemic lapses in safeguarding vulnerable members against intra-family violence.
2. Balochistan (Jhal Magsi, November 2025): A land dispute between the Solangi and Wazdani Magsi tribes—interconnected through extended familial ties—degenerated into a gun battle, resulting in the death of Bachal Magsi. Authorities intervened post-incident, but the failure to preemptively address the feud through tribal councils or legal channels allowed it to turn deadly, underscoring ongoing lawlessness in resource-related family conflicts.

